70 Nathan the prophet

The prophet who brought David God's greatest promise and his hardest rebuke.

Nathan was a prophet at David's court in Jerusalem. Scripture shows him at three turning points in David's reign. First, he brought God's promise that David's house and throne would last for ever. Second, after David's sin with Bathsheba and the killing of Uriah, he told the king a story about a rich man who stole a poor man's only lamb, then said, "Thou art the man." Third, in David's old age, he made sure Solomon, not Adonijah, took the throne. He spoke God's word faithfully, in comfort and in rebuke.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Natan*, "he has given" or "gift"
Role	Prophet at the court of David and at the start of Solomon's reign
When	David's reign in Jerusalem to c. 970 BC
Key places	Jerusalem, the spring of Gihon
Key people	David, Bathsheba, Solomon, Zadok the priest, Adonijah
Writings	"The book of Nathan the prophet," not preserved (1 Chronicles 29:29)
Not the same as	Nathan son of David and Bathsheba (1 Chronicles 3:5; Luke 3:31)
New Testament	Not named

"And Nathan said to David, Thou art the man."

2 Samuel 12:7, KJV

The life of Nathan the prophet

Dates are approximate (BC). Scripture gives no dates for Nathan's first two scenes. They fall in David's reign in Jerusalem (c. 1003–970 BC). The last scene is c. 970 BC.

David at rest in Jerusalem

Brings God's covenant

David wants to build a house for the ark. Nathan first says, "Go, do all that is in thine heart." That night God tells Nathan that David's son will build it, and God will build David a lasting house. *2 Samuel 7:1–17*

After Uriah's death

Confronts the king

God sends Nathan to David. He tells the story of the rich man and the poor man's lamb, then says, "Thou art the man." David confesses, and Nathan announces both forgiveness and consequences. *2 Samuel 12:1–15*

At Solomon's birth

Names the child

God sends word by Nathan, and through him the baby is named Jedidiah, "beloved of the LORD." The LORD loves the child. *2 Samuel 12:24–25*

c. 970 BC

Warns of Adonijah

Adonijah proclaims himself king and leaves Nathan out. Nathan tells Bathsheba to remind David of his promise, then comes in himself to confirm her words. *1 Kings 1:5–27*

c. 970 BC

Anoints Solomon

At David's command, Nathan and Zadok take Solomon on the king's mule to Gihon and anoint him king. The trumpet sounds, and the people shout, "God save king Solomon." *1 Kings 1:32–45*

Group notes

Key activities

2 Chronicles 29:25 says the temple music was arranged by command of David, Gad the seer and Nathan the prophet. 1 Kings 4:5 names two officials who were sons of a Nathan, but it is not certain which Nathan is meant.

1. **Brought back a changed message.** He first told David to go ahead with the temple. After God spoke to him that night, he returned with God's own answer. *2 Samuel 7:3–5*
2. **Delivered God's covenant.** He told David that God would raise up his son and establish his throne for ever. *2 Samuel 7:8–17*
3. **Told a story that opened a heart.** "The rich man had exceeding many flocks and herds: But the poor man had nothing, save one little ewe lamb." *2 Samuel 12:1–4*
4. **Named the sin plainly.** He said, "Thou art the man," and listed what God had given David and what David had done. *2 Samuel 12:7–12*
5. **Announced forgiveness.** When David said, "I have sinned against the LORD," Nathan replied, "The LORD also hath put away thy sin; thou shalt not die." *2 Samuel 12:13*
6. **Protected God's choice of king.** He planned with Bathsheba to warn David about Adonijah. *1 Kings 1:11–27*
7. **Anointed Solomon.** With Zadok the priest, he anointed Solomon at Gihon. *1 Kings 1:38–45*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nathan.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 7:1–17; 1 Chronicles 17:1–15	God's covenant with David
2 Samuel 12:1–25	The parable, the rebuke and Solomon's naming
1 Kings 1:8–45	Nathan helps secure Solomon's throne
1 Chronicles 29:29; 2 Chronicles 9:29	His writings cited as sources
Psalm 51	Title: "when Nathan the prophet came unto him"
Echo: Proverbs 27:6	"Faithful are the wounds of a friend"

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:32–33	Jesus promised "the throne of his father David"
Echo: Matthew 18:15	Telling a brother his fault privately

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Nathan approach David in 2 Samuel 12:1–7, and how did David react before he knew the story was about him?
2. *Understand:* Nathan's first answer in 2 Samuel 7:3 was changed by God's word that night. What does it show that he went back to David with a different message?
3. *Apply:* Nathan loved David enough to confront him. Who in your life has that freedom, and do you give it to them?
4. *Apply:* Is there a hard but loving word you need to speak to someone? How could you say it wisely?